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Scientists wary of cuts in research

Medical funding may be at risk under Trump

By Kay Lazar
GLOBE STAFF

In April 2017, three months after Donald Trump was inaugurated president, tens of thousands of scientists and their supporters gathered on Boston Common in the damp, chilly air to protest the new administration's proposed steep budget cuts to medical research.

The March for Science, echoed in similar rallies across the country, pushed back on Trump's statements denying climate change and his administration's plan to slash billions of dollars from the National Institutes of Health, the federal government's largest funder of medical research.

Today, as Trump assembles his team to return to the White House, scientists on the front lines are worried anew. Trump's pick to lead the Department of Health and Human Services, Robert F. Kennedy Jr., is a vocal critic of vaccines and mainstream medicine who has vowed to replace 600 employees at the NIH. He has called for devoting half of the NIH's research budget to "preventive, alternative, and holistic approaches to health," and away from infectious diseases at a time when the COVID virus continues to mutate, bird flu is spreading to people and animals, and mpox appears to have evolved into a more dangerous form.

Scientists are also uneasy about Trump's choice to lead the NIH, Dr. Jay Bhattacharya, a Stanford University health economist who criticized COVID lockdowns in the first months of the pandemic. Reports suggest he wants to tie future NIH awards to the perceived de-

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Investigators focused on the possibility that a Russian air defense system struck the plane that crashed in Kazakhstan, killing 38. A3.

Mayor Michelle Wu is trying to regain possession of the narrative on the White Stadium rebuild, writes Shirley Leung. Is it too late? **B5.**

New home tests for COVID-19 are now available — and they will also screen for two types of flu virus. B1.



Melting part

Friday: A bit warmer. High 37-42. Low 27-32.

Saturday: Drizzle. High 38-43. Low 35-40.

High tide: 8:20 a.m., 8:59 p.m.
Sunrise: 7:12 Sunset: 4:18

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250 years later, the battle is on

Organizers of events in April to commemorate Lexington and Concord say they've got to have more money to handle 200,000 spectators

By Brian MacQuarrie
GLOBE STAFF

As the 250th anniversary of the battles of Lexington and Concord nears, planning for this once-in-a-generation celebration includes a sprawling array of parades, reenactments, tributes — and more than a little frustration.

For an April 19 event that is expected to attract more than 200,000 spectators, organizers said they still do not have enough transportation resources

to match all the needs of the throng that will descend on Lexington and Concord that day.

The House earlier this year approved \$325,000 in transportation and other costs for the four "Battle Road" communities involved in the commemoration — Lexington, Concord, Arlington, and Lincoln — but the appropriation failed to emerge from year-end budget negotiations with the Senate.

"We're going to see the tourists, the traffic, the congestion,

and we really need help with transportation — with getting people out of their cars, and helping with parking and shuttle buses," said Suzanne Barry, chair of the Lexington 250th Committee and vice chair of the town's Select Board.

"It's been challenging, locally. For whatever reason, the rest of the state hasn't agreed on the importance of funding this," Barry said.

The earmark discarded in
ANNIVERSARY, Page A7



MARKING A TRAGIC DAY WHEN DISASTER STRUCK

Twenty years after a massive Indian Ocean tsunami hit Indonesia's Aceh province and killed about 230,000 people across a dozen countries, mourners walked through the Ban Nam Khem Tsunami Memorial Park wall in the province of Phang Nga on Thursday. In Banda Aceh, one of the areas hit hardest by the tsunami and the powerful earthquake that triggered it, a woman wept during prayers. Early warning systems have been installed in coastal areas over the past two decades to alert residents and give them time to seek safety. **A7.**



REZA SAIFULLAH/ASSOCIATED PRESS



LILLIAN SUWANRUMPHA/AFP VIA GETTY IMAGES

'We have no control over how they develop their relationship and that's the beauty of it.'

DANA GRIFFIN, *founder of Eldera*

Kids and seniors finding they actually have a lot in common

With both groups facing social isolation, programs bridge gap

By Kay Lazar
GLOBE STAFF

How old is old?

That was the question put to a group of Salem high school students earlier this fall, and the consensus was that someone around age 56 was probably old.

But that image melted away when they were paired for 90 minutes with several adults a good decade or two past "old," and they discovered that one of those oldsters had a TikTok account, another, a 70-something woman, was still teaching yoga, and another, near 90, was downright funny.

"Almost all the people there were still active and didn't look their age," Julian Tremblay, a junior at Salem Academy Charter School, said weeks after attending the session. Now, his definition of old is not measured in years but in ability.

"I think old," he said recently, "is when you can't provide for yourself anymore."

At a time when the world seems riven by differences, initiatives to bridge the distance between young and old are gaining ground. The Salem gathering, organized by a community-based initiative known as Salem for All Ages, was designed to help teens and older adults foster a better understanding and appreciation of one another, and ease social isolation for both groups.

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PHOTOS BY DAVID L. RYAN/GLOBE STAFF

Kathleen McGuire, 73, and Suin Lee, 12, who's in South Korea, say they enjoy their weekly Zoom chat.

For N.H. Rep. Kuster, it's right time to make way for others

By Tal Kopan
GLOBE STAFF

WASHINGTON — As Representative Annie M. Kuster leaves Congress, the New Hampshire Democrat is hoping some of her colleagues might be inspired to do the same — and wishes President Biden had earlier, as well.

Kuster, 68, said her decision to retire was based on many factors, including Donald Trump's approaching return to the presidency, but she hopes it will also encourage Democrats to make room for younger generations in the halls of power.

"I'm trying to set a better example," Kuster said. "I think there are colleagues — and some of whom are still very successful and very productive — but others who just stay forever."

And as for a role in a new Trump-led Washington, she said: "I'm just not the best gladiator for it right now."

Beyond a desire to make room for new generations, Kuster said the events of Jan. 6, 2021, and Trump's return to the White House weighed heavily on her.

Kuster was in the House chamber when insurrectionists who breached the Capitol closed in, narrowly escaping with other members before the rioters reached the corridor she fled through.

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